

refused to work on any system that had BlindWrite installed. The Patin-Couffin layer that installs with the default installation of the software was found to be the culprit.



The Samsung SW-352's 8 MB buffer does not seem to help it

The packaging and contents of all the drives were similar. Liteon and Sony were the only drives that had a half-height form-factor. This is useful for people who

have micro-ATX boards and small cabinets. Also, another advantage was the support for the Mount Rainier standard. Most drives featured a standard single eject button and multi-coloured LED on the front bezel. Samsung was the only drive that had a 52X CD write and 16X DVD read speeds. BenQ was the slowest with 32X CD write and 12X DVD read speeds.

We used a non-encrypted data DVD-ROM for our Nero DVD Speed tests. The test results were quite surprising, to say the least. Especially the burst rate tests,

Combination drives

With the advent of DVD-ROM drives and the spread of CD-R and RW drives, it was just a matter of time before drives that combined the two began popping up in the market. Combination drives are now very affordable and also space saving. International brands such as Toshiba, TEAC and Hitachi are still not available in the Indian market, and we tested the five available brands—BenQ, LG, LITEON, Samsung and Sony.

Decision Maker

You want	You need	Look for	The models	Price range
To backup a lot of data	A high performing CD-Writer	A 52X CD-Writer with more buffer size	Krypton 52X/32X/52X or Liteon LTR-52327S	Rs 2,900 to Rs 3,500
A multi-purpose drive	A good combination drive	A combination drive that gives good performance	Sony CRX 300 A or Liteon LTC-48161H	Rs 4,200 to Rs 6,300

DVD Regions and Its Intricacies

Soon after the DVD format was standardised world-wide, the movie industry divided the world into six regions. These are:

Region 1: USA and Canada

Region 2: Europe, Near East, South Africa and Japan

Region 3: South East Asia

Region 4: Australia, Middle and South America

Region 5: Africa, Asia and Eastern Europe.

Region 6: The People's Republic of China.

This was done mainly to stop the movement of movies across boundaries. Earlier, PC DVD-ROM manufacturers earlier used to manufacture region-free DVD drives that could play DVD's from any region. Such drives were called RPC-1 drives. But after January 1, 2000, this changed; The new RPC 2 drives were region locked. You can only change the region five times, after which your drive is locked to the last selected region.

For the region protection to work, the disc itself must be set to a specific region code (which most discs are), and then either the DVD drive or the playback software must match the disc's code to

their own code for playback to work. If the drive itself is locked, the software or hardware decoder will rely on the drive to confirm the region match. If the drive is region free, then the decoders try to enforce the region protection.

If your drive is set to a specific region, you will be unable to play a disc from a different region. This can not be bypassed without replacing the checking mechanism within the drive itself. This can only be done with a firmware update.

However, there is software that help the drive bypass this protection. One such software is DVD Region Free, which we used to test the drives and see if it could bypass the region-coding protection. We used a Region 1 DVD to test the drives. None of the drives were set to any specific region and with DVD Region Free disabled; the dialog box to set the drive to a specific region popped up when we tried playing the DVD in PowerDVD XP. Once the software was enabled, the DVD automatically started to play. The software side-stepped the code and successfully played the DVD on all the drives.

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